CONNECT DAILY

Thursday 15 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Ofsted's leadership crisis sharpened overnight - a snap NEU poll found 98% no confidence in chief inspector Sir Martyn Oliver, and governors separately called report-card inspections 'brutal'.

  → **For your school:** *NEU wants Oliver to go, inspections paused, and an urgent framework review - worth watching before your next inspection window.*

- Locally: Sheffield's finance committee votes Monday on £602k funding for a Firth Park Academy expansion adding three new SEND rooms alongside 30 extra Year 7 places.
- From tomorrow (16 Oct), employers can start consulting staff on pay policies for the 3.5% 2026-27 teacher pay award - though the Pay Order itself still has to clear Parliament.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

16 Oct 2026 — Employers in England can begin consulting staff on updated pay policies for the 2026-27 teacher pay award.

19 Oct 2026 — Sheffield City Council finance and performance committee votes on £602k funding for the Firth Park Academy SEND-places expansion.

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

OFSTED LEADERSHIP UNDER FIRE

- **NEU snap survey: 98% no confidence.** A snap poll of almost 7,000 NEU members in English state schools, run overnight 12-13 October, found 98% have no confidence in Ofsted's current leadership and 96% back an immediate pause on inspections. General secretary Daniel Kebede said Oliver 'has lost the confidence of the profession and it is time for him to go'. (Tes)
- **Governors: inspections are 'brutal'.** The National Governance Association's annual survey found governors describing report-card inspections as 'brutal', with some school leadership teams 'breaking down routinely' under the pressure - despite 71% saying their last inspection gave a fair and accurate picture, up only 3 points on 2022's record low. (Tes)
- **Second union's no-confidence vote.** ASCL's council passed its own no-confidence vote in Ofsted's leadership last week over unaddressed workload and wellbeing concerns. (FE Week)

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Firth Park Academy set for SEND-focused expansion.** Sheffield's finance and performance committee meets Monday 19 October to approve passing £602,000 of government funding to Lift Schools, part of a £701,312 scheme adding three SEND rooms, refurbished creative-arts space and upgraded science labs - raising Firth Park's admission number from 240 to 270 to help meet a projected secondary-places shortfall in 2027/28 and 2028/29. (The Star)

PAY & FUNDING

- **Pay policy consultations open from tomorrow.** From 16 October, employers can consult staff on pay policies reflecting the accepted 3.5% uplift for 2026-27 (5% at the bottom of the unqualified range), backdated to 1 September. The Pay Order itself still has to clear its parliamentary praying period before arrears follow - worth flagging to business managers as a timing uncertainty. (NASUWT)

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

98%

of NEU members surveyed say they have no confidence in Ofsted's current leadership - from a snap poll of almost 7,000 teachers in English state schools, taken 12-13 October 2026.

NEU snap survey

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.